



Coyote vs. Acme Review: A Well-Done Romp in Spite of All Odds

Coyote vs. Acme, released on August 28th, 2026, is an animated/live action comedy film directed by Dave Green, produced by Warner Bros. Discovery and distributed by Ketchup Entertainment. It stars Will Forte as billboard lawyer Kevin Avery, Lana Condor as Kevin's niece and intern Paige, John Cena as Acme Corporation's chief lawyer Buddy Crane, and Wile E. Coyote and the Road Runner as themselves, alongside their fellow Looney Tunes.

Based on the [1990 *New Yorker* article of the same name](#), it tells the story of the titular Coyote suing Acme Corporation for the countless products he has used in his pursuit of the Road Runner over the years, with the help of reluctant billboard lawyer Kevin Avery. Despite original plans to shelve it by Warner Bros, the film was eventually picked up for wide theatrical release by Ketchup Entertainment.

Coyote vs. Acme is a good movie, with a strong sense of timing, and a gag-a-minute pace that ensures people of all comedic tastes will find something to laugh about, from puns, to background details, or even just a simple anvil to the head. It successfully evokes the spirit of classic Looney Tunes shorts, and may be the best live action/animation film since *Who Framed Roger Rabbit?*, from which it takes great influence. It has been reviewed highly, with a 95% audience and critic score on *Rotten Tomatoes* and a 7.5 average rating on IMDB, and has so far made approximately \$64 million

worldwide against its estimated \$70 million budget, which is encouraging given Warner Bros' plan to throw it away for a tax write-off.



The Cancellation Run-Down: What Happened with Warner Bros?

As mentioned above, Warner Bros. (the film's producers and rights-holders of the Looney Tunes) completed the film, but announced publicly in November 2023 that it would shelve the film so that it could receive a \$30 million tax write-off credit. This was the third instance of Warner Bros. canceling a movie that was complete or nearly complete for a credit; it had done the same to *Scoob!*, *Holiday Haunt* and *Batgirl* in 2022, which were in the midst of post-production when they were axed.

Thankfully, upon Warner Bros.' announcement of cancellation, industry stars and the movie's crew alike kicked up an internet campaign to save the movie. Notable voices in the movement include James Gunn, who helped develop the story, popular filmmaking duo Lord & Miller, and director Dave Green. Having all seen the completed cut of the movie, they insisted it was too good to be consigned to the trash, and helped start the hashtag #ReleaseCoyoteVsACME.

Within four days of the campaign's start, Warner Bros. declared that it was open to selling the film's distribution rights. But no company was willing to meet their asking price – reportedly over \$100 million – until March 2025, when it was sold to Ketchup Entertainment for \$50 million. Ketchup Entertainment had previously purchased another abandoned Looney Tunes film from Warner Bros., *The Day the Earth Blew Up*. Using the flames of the controversy to their advantage, Ketchup's marketing campaign was wily and effective; its first trailer pitched the film as "The Movie Acme Doesn't Want You To See," garnering millions of views on YouTube.



Plot Synopsis (Spoilers Ahead)

The movie opens with a classic Road Runner/Coyote showdown, which works well to (re)introduce the audience to their eternal conflict and set the film's tone. By hiding metal ball bearings in a plate of bird seed, Wile E. Coyote uses a magnetic glove to pull the Road Runner towards him, until it malfunctions, letting the Road Runner escape, and flattening Coyote with a semi truck. We then follow Coyote back to his home in a cave, surrounded by towering piles of failed plans and the Acme Corporation cartoon products that failed him (anvils, catapults, rocket skates, you name it). Then, spying an advertisement for Kevin Avery's cartoon accident law firm, he sets off to Albuquerque to get even with Acme.

Kevin Avery, a dejected slip-and-fall settlement lawyer for cartoons, is totally unprepared for the scope of the legal campaign that Coyote wants to wage. Presenting a lawsuit against every cartoon product they have produced over the decades, they draw the ire of Buddy Crane, the chief legal counsel of Acme, when they refuse to settle for a tiny sum. Unprepared and nervous, Avery bungles the trial and gets it dismissed, but the media coverage has caught federal attention, and Congress summons both parties to a hearing in D.C. In the quest for more substantial evidence, Avery, Coyote, and Avery's law intern (and niece) Paige discover a major scandal – that, for decades, Acme has been testing defective cartoon products on the buying public research and development for their other products.

Armed with this knowledge, the team heads to D.C., but they come to an impasse when Avery confronts Wile E. Coyote about his true intentions. He discovered that the lawsuit was just an elaborate ruse to get the Road Runner to testify in court, so the Coyote could catch him. Coyote leaves, dejected, and Kevin and Paige are left to meet Congress without their plaintiff. But during an impassioned speech by Kevin about Wile E.'s character, Coyote comes back to complete the hearing. When Road Runner arrives to testify, Coyote is moved to tears by the sympathy on display, despite their decades of animosity. And while Congress eventually dismisses the case for lack of evidence, Acme is humiliated in the hearing by Coyote's trap, and Kevin Avery's law firm is mobbed by cartoons looking to sue Acme for their defective products. Wile E. Coyote and the Averys part ways amicably, and Coyote returns to his one true calling, happy and content to chase the Road Runner across the desert forevermore.

Review

Coyote vs. Acme is an admirable extension of the Wile E. Coyote/Road Runner shorts. The tone, pacing, and gag style are all spot-on to their source material, and it combines charming references and call-backs with new ideas seamlessly. While nothing in particular had me busting a gut with laughter, I never found myself not enjoying the film, and I had many chuckles throughout. One element I particularly enjoyed, because I found it to be novel for films of this style, was that the Looney Tunes and their antics were an accepted part of the movie's world, unlike most other live action/animation films which treat the animated characters as strange, and alien.

Beyond the script, the film's other elements, likewise, are rock-solid. The blending of animation and live action is seamless, and the design and animation of the 'Tunes is spot-on, especially considering the challenge of needing to render two-dimensional drawings from all angles. The soundtrack offers a symphony to the ears: remixing classical orchestral tracks straight from the original cartoons, and needle-dropping modern hits, like DJ Shadow and Run the Jewels' "Nobody Speak" with the Road Runner censoring the foul language with "Meep-Meep"s. All the screws are tightened, and there is no flaw in the composition of the movie.

The film also contains rich elements for meta-commentary exploration, especially given the debacle around its release. The conglomerate mega-corporation intentionally releases defective products to cut costs to the detriment of their customers. The cartoons are effectively second-class citizens, forced to use the defective devices, with their pain and suffering written off by the humans because they're "used to it." The legal system and government are influenced by the wealthy to the common man's detriment. While *Coyote vs. Acme* never goes deeper than suggesting or winking at these themes, it serves as an interesting starting point for potential deeper discussion.



Recommendation and Verdict

Coyote vs. Acme is a film the whole family can enjoy. While those not familiar with the Looney Tunes may not understand some references, they will still enjoy the conventional gags and feel gratified by the emotional beats and happy ending. While it may not be mind-blowing or otherwise wildly outstanding for a film of its caliber, the film is a thoroughly enjoyable experience, and it is definitely worth your Wile (E. Coyote).

Final Score: 7 out of 10